

Sponsored message



Audience-funded
nonprofit news



LISTEN



NEWS

South Pasadena cancels contract with Flock Safety, citing privacy concerns



Libby Rainey is a general assignment reporter. She covers the news that shapes Los Angeles and how people change the city in return.

Published Mar 19, 2026 1:49 PM



There are 27 Flock cameras installed around the city of South Pasadena.

This story is free to read because readers choose to support LAist. If you find value in independent local reporting, [make a donation to power our newsroom today](#).

The South Pasadena City Council moved Wednesday not to renew a contract with Flock Safety, a controversial surveillance company that operates AI-powered automated license plate readers in thousands of communities across the U.S.

The move ends the use of 14 cameras installed around town while city officials seek alternative camera vendors.

The city still has a second contract with Flock for 13 operating cameras, which capture the license plate numbers and locations of passing cars. That information is temporarily stored in a database that's shared with law enforcement agencies across the state.

The council's decision follows [public outcry](#) after reports that some local law enforcement agencies in Southern California [illegally shared license plate reader data with federal immigration agents](#). Those included the Riverside County Sheriff's Office, which South Pasadena [shares its data with](#).

Keep up with LAist.

If you're enjoying this article, you'll love our daily newsletter, The LA Report. Each weekday, catch up on the 5 most pressing stories to start your morning in 3 minutes or less.

Email

SUBSCRIBE

Trending on LAist



All aboard the D Line! First phase of historic Metro line extension opens

LA City Council moves to ban LAPD from making pretextual stops

A \$10M fundraiser could save the land around Big Bear's bald eagle nest. It's halfway over

"We probably wouldn't be here tonight if it'd been a different federal administration. We could trust more, not so much chaos," City Councilmember Michael Cacciotti said at Wednesday's meeting. "Many of our residents are very concerned about the misuse and abuse of data."

The decision was not unanimous. City Councilmember Jon Primuth said he thought people speaking out against Flock did not represent the majority of residents in South Pasadena. He also expressed concern about moving to a different vendor for automated license plate readers, since so many surrounding cities use the Flock network. Pasadena and San Marino both have Flock cameras, as do many cities in the L.A. area.

Sponsored message

"I don't think there's anything to be gained by canceling a contract right now," Primuth said.

Council members also discussed shortening the time period that the city holds onto its data from 30 to 15 days.

South Pasadena joins a handful of California cities that have reconsidered their contracts with Flock in recent months. The first was Santa Cruz, which killed its contract with Flock in January following reports that the city's data was accessed by agencies outside of California and shared with ICE.

The Oxnard Police Department also suspended its use of Flock license plate readers, after an audit revealed that data from the city's cameras was made available to federal law enforcement agencies between February and March of 2025 through a "nationwide query" setting, against the city's wishes and state law.

Flock responded to the incident, saying out-of-state law enforcement agencies' access to some of its camera networks was "inadvertent" and it had strengthened its protections. The company also says it does not work with ICE or any agency within the Department of Homeland Security.

The incidents have sparked a deeper debate around automated license plate readers, which have become ubiquitous in many communities without much notice. Local law enforcement agencies say the cameras have greatly enhanced their ability to solve

crimes, while privacy advocates including the ACLU have called the technology a dangerous "dragnet."

While South Pasadena scales back Flock's presence, some of its neighbors are adding more. Pasadena has 61 Flock automated license plate readers and plans to install 11 additional cameras.

You come to LAist because you want independent reporting and trustworthy local information. Our newsroom doesn't answer to shareholders looking to turn a profit. Instead, **we answer to you and our connected community. We are free to tell the full truth, to hold power to account without fear or favor, and to follow facts wherever they lead.** Our only loyalty is to our audiences and our mission: to inform, engage, and strengthen our community.

Right now, LAist has lost \$1.7M in annual funding due to Congress clawing back money already approved. The support we receive from readers like you will determine how fully our newsroom can continue informing, serving, and strengthening Southern California.

If this story helped you today, **please become a monthly member today to help sustain this mission. It just takes 1 minute to donate below.**

Your **tax-deductible donation** keeps LAist independent and accessible to everyone.

Megan Garvey
Senior Vice President News, Editor in Chief

Make your tax-deductible donation today

Monthly	One time

\$10

\$15

\$30

\$ other

SUPPORT NOW



Secure Payment

Trending on LAist

FOOD

The birria soup dumpling is here and it's the most LA thing we've ever eaten

VOTER GUIDES

Los Angeles mayor: Who's running in the June 2 primary and why it matters

CRIMINAL JUSTICE

Turner's Outdoorsman is linked to the largest share of guns traced to crimes in California

TRANSPORTATION & MOBILITY

Arbitrator sides with union claiming LAX People Mover subcontractor owes workers back pay

The Brief

Homelessness in LA

City agrees to boost housing and shelter options

3 hours ago

OC Dems pull endorsement

Assessor candidate denies former staff claims

3 hours ago

CA controller race

A look at the top candidates for controller

4 hours ago

CalFresh in college

Study shows food access keeps students on track

4 hours ago

Hantavirus outbreak

LA officials monitoring potential virus reports

6 hours ago

Keep up with our local independent news

The L.A. Report newsletter is your daily morning update on the biggest stories in the Los Angeles region.

Email

SUBSCRIBE



[About LAist](#)

[Newsletters](#)

[Editorial Staff](#)

[Contact Us](#)

[Careers](#)

[Support Us](#)

[Sponsorship](#)

[Ethics & Guidelines](#)

[Public Information](#)



LAist is an independent, nonprofit newsroom that is also home to L.A.'s largest NPR station broadcasting at 89.3 FM. We center our coverage around people and communities, not institutions or policies. We hold power to account. We are unapologetically L.A.